

Précis Writing



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What is Précis?

- ✓ A précis is the gist of a passage expressed in a few words as possible.
- ✓ It should express only the main theme of passage.

Characteristics of a good précis

- ✓ **Brevity:** A précis should be brief yet comprehensive. It should be approximately one-third of the passage.
- ✓ **Clarity:** It should be clear in expressing the ideas. The order of the ideas of the passage should be as same as in the original text. All the main ideas of the passage should be invariably contained in the précis.
- ✓ **Completeness:** It should include all the essential points in the précis, and all the points should be well-connected.

Writing a good Précis

- Underline the key sentences and important points.
- Prepare a rough draft with the underlined points.
- Include all the main points.
- Shorten the long sentences.
 - ✓ Use simple sentences
 - ✓ Write in an active voice
- Do not copy any point from the original passage.
- Avoid grammatical and spelling mistakes.

Writing a good Précis

- Write in your own words and in reported speech.
- Do not insert any question in the Précis.
- Irrelevant and Incidental points, such as examples, illustrations, and comments by authors, may be omitted.
- Give a title even if not asked.

Example

Original Sentence:

"The rapid growth of social media has greatly influenced the way young people interact and communicate."

"Wrong (copied):

"The rapid growth of social media has greatly influenced the way young people interact and communicate."

Correct (your own words):

"Social media has significantly changed how young people communicate."

Example

Original:

"The meeting was conducted by the principal."

Passive in Precis (not preferred):

"The meeting was conducted by the principal."

Active in Precis (better):

"The principal conducted the meeting."

Summary

Aspect	Required for Precis Writing	Explanation
Copying Original Sentences	 No	Rewrite ideas in your own words
Active Voice	 Prefer	Clear and Concise
Passive Voice	 Allowed but avoid heavy use	Can make text weak
Reported (Indirect Speech)	 Always	Summarizes author's ideas
Personal Opinion	 Never	Keep the author's tone and message

Example of shortening up a section

A good book is one of our best friends. It is the same today as it always was, and it will never change. It is the most patient and cheerful companion. It does not turn its back upon us in times of adversity or distress. It always receives us with the same kindness, amusing and instructing us in youth, comforting and consoling us in old age.

Précis

A book is a patient, never-changing, and cheerful friend helping us in sorrow, in youth, comforting us, and pacifying us in old age.

Reference

Langan, J., & John, L. (1978). *Reading and study skills*. New York: McGraw-Hill.

THANKS.

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